THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 26, 2026 · DINNER FOR 12

Thanksgiving Plan

Eight recipes, one oven, and a schedule that pushes almost everything into Tuesday and Wednesday so Thursday is mostly reheating, carving, and eating.

TURKEY	MONDAY	TUESDAY NIGHT	WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY
14–16 lb, dry-brined	Optional: salt the turkey	~1½ hrs	~3–4 hrs	Turkey + reheat

Before the week starts

Two decisions that drive the rest of the schedule.

Frozen turkey? Move it to the fridge by Friday, Nov 20. A 15 lb bird needs about 3–4 days to thaw in the fridge, and it has to be fully thawed before it's salted on Monday or Tuesday. A fresh turkey skips this step; order one for pickup on Monday or Tuesday.

Why 14–16 lb instead of the recipe's 10–12: the usual rule is about 1¼ lb per person, which also leaves leftovers. A bigger bird needs longer in the oven: plan on 30 min at 450°F, then about 2–2½ hrs at 350°F. Go by the thermometer (165°F in the thickest part of the thigh), not the clock.

Should someone start Monday? It's nice to have but not required. The turkey needs **at least 1 day** in the salt (up to 3), then 4–12 hours uncovered in the fridge. If someone salts it Monday night, it gets 2 days, which is better. If not, salting it first thing Tuesday night still works: 24 hours in the bag, then uncovered overnight Wednesday.

Monday – Wednesday

Checkboxes save in this browser, so you can tick things off as you go.

Monday, Nov 23

Optional

- [ ] **Do the big shop**
  Everything on the list. Buy the bread now so it can go stale by Wednesday.
- [ ] **Dry-brine the turkey**
  Take out the giblets and neck. Pat everything dry. Rub all over (neck too) with 7½ tsp kosher salt (½ tsp per lb), 1 Tbsp pepper, and the zest of 1 lemon. Put it in a 2-gallon bag with the thyme, sage, and 6 smashed garlic cloves. Set it on a rimmed sheet pan in the fridge. **Flip it once a day.**

Tuesday, Nov 24 · evening

~1½ hrs

- [ ] **Turkey: salt it, or flip it**
  If nobody did it Monday, dry-brine it first thing (see Monday). If you salt it tonight, flip it before bed or first thing Wednesday morning.
- [ ] **Make the gravy (1½×)**
  20 min. Cook the onion in butter, brown the flour, then whisk in the stock. Cool it, cover, and refrigerate. It keeps up to 5 days.
- [ ] **Make the cranberry-orange relish (2×)**
  5 min. Pulse it in the food processor **in two batches**. The recipe says it tastes better after a day or two in the fridge.
- [ ] **Tear the bread for the stuffing**
  Tear both loaves into chunks and spread them on sheet pans, uncovered, so they're stale by tomorrow.
- [ ] **Clear fridge space**
  By Wednesday night the fridge has to hold the turkey on a sheet pan plus six make-ahead dishes. A cooler with ice can take the drinks.

Wednesday, Nov 25

Main prep day · ~3–4 hrs

- [ ] **Mashed potatoes (3×)**
  Make them all the way through (Step 8), then refrigerate them covered in a baking dish. They keep up to 5 days. Do not freeze.
- [ ] **Roast the carrots and brussels sprouts together · 375–400°F**
  Carrots (1.5×): roast until tender, add the parsley, cool, and refrigerate (keeps 4–5 days). **Sprouts (2×):** roast on two sheet pans and stir in the maple syrup at 30 min (Steps 1–4). Pull them out a little underdone, cool, and refrigerate. They finish on Thursday.
- [ ] **Toast and chop the hazelnuts**
  Do this while the oven is hot. 8–10 min, then rub off the skins in a towel. Store airtight at room temperature.
- [ ] **Stuffing (2×), cooked and baked**
  Pulse the stale bread into very coarse crumbs and cook them with the butter, onion, nuts, sage, scallions, and parsley. Bake in two 9×13 dishes for about 45 min at 375°F. Cool and refrigerate; it reheats Thursday. The recipe allows cooking it up to 3 days ahead.
- [ ] **Blanch the green beans (2×)**
  Boil 3–5 min, then rinse under cold water. Dry them well and refrigerate in a bag lined with paper towels. Chop the shallots and refrigerate them too.
- [ ] **Pick up the pies and dinner rolls**
  Pies can sit at room temperature overnight (refrigerate any pumpkin or cream pies). Keep the rolls in their bag.
- [ ] **Unwrap the turkey to dry the skin · around 9:00 PM**
  Take it out of the bag (throw out the herbs), pat it dry, and put it back on the sheet pan **uncovered** in the fridge. It needs 4–12 hours this way; the time shown is 12 hours before it comes out of the fridge on Thursday.

Thursday, Nov 26

There's one oven, so the plan is: turkey in the oven, turkey out to rest, then everything else reheats at 400°F while it rests.

- [ ] **9:00 AM** — Take the turkey out of the fridge and let it sit at room temperature for 1 hour.
- [ ] **9:45 AM** — Preheat the oven to 450°F `450°`
  Roasting pan: pour in the cider plus enough white wine to reach ¼ inch, then add 1 quartered onion, 6 garlic cloves, and the bay leaves. Stuff the other onion and the lemon quarters into the bird. Brush the skin well with melted butter or oil, then set the turkey breast-up on the rack.
- [ ] **10:00 AM** — **Turkey goes in** `450° · 30 min`
- [ ] **10:30 AM** — **Cover the breast with foil and turn the oven down to 350°F** `350°`
- [ ] **11:30 AM** — Take the stuffing, sprouts, carrots, and potatoes out of the fridge to lose their chill. Set the table.
- [ ] **12:00 PM** — Start checking the thigh temperature. You're aiming for **165°F**. A 14–16 lb bird usually needs 2–2½ hrs at 350°F.
- [ ] **12:30 PM** — **Turkey out to rest, loosely tented with foil. Turn the oven up to 400°F** `400°`
  The rest can run 30–60 min, which is your buffer if the bird runs long. Save the pan drippings for the gravy.
- [ ] **12:45 PM** — Stuffing goes in, covered with foil, about 30 min. Uncover it for the last 10 min to crisp the top.
- [ ] **1:15 PM** — Sprouts and carrots go in, about 15 min `400°`
  The carrots are also fine served at room temperature if the oven is full. Start reheating the potatoes in a pot over medium with a splash of cream, stirring now and then.
- [ ] **1:30 PM** — **Carve the turkey. Reheat the gravy over low heat and whisk in the skimmed pan drippings.**
- [ ] **1:40 PM** — Warm the dinner rolls, wrapped in foil, for 8–10 min `400°`
- [ ] **1:48 PM** — Green beans: cook the shallots in butter for about 1 min, add the beans, salt, and pepper, toss until hot, then add the lemon juice. Toss the sprouts with the hazelnuts. Set out the relish.
- [ ] **2:00 PM** — **Dinner** 🦃
- [ ] **3:30 PM** — Dessert: whip the cream (or shake the cans) and slice the pies

Shopping list

Already scaled for 12 people, with every recipe combined. The small print says which dish each item is for.

Bread, dessert & wine

- [ ] Dinner rolls · **2 dozen**
  Pick them up Wednesday and warm them Thursday
- [ ] Pies · **3**
  About 24 slices. For example, pumpkin, apple, and pecan.
- [ ] Whipped cream · **1 pint heavy cream + 2 Tbsp sugar**
  Whip it right before dessert. Two cans of whipped cream work too.
- [ ] Really expensive wine · **Jeff & Lori**
  Their job. Nobody else needs to buy this.

Meat & stock

- [ ] Turkey · **14–16 lb**
  Fresh if you can get one. Frozen means thawing by Fri 11/20.
- [ ] Turkey or chicken stock, low-sodium · **3 quarts**
  Gravy (about 7 cups), plus extra to thin it

Produce

- [ ] Russet potatoes · **6 lb**
  Mashed potatoes
- [ ] Brussels sprouts · **3 lb**
  Sprouts
- [ ] Carrots · **3 lb**
  Roasted carrots
- [ ] Thin green beans (haricots verts) · **2 lb**
  Green beans
- [ ] Fresh cranberries · **2 bags (12 oz)**
  Relish
- [ ] Navel oranges · **2**
  Relish
- [ ] Lemons · **2**
  Turkey (zest and cavity), green beans (juice)
- [ ] Yellow onions · **6**
  Turkey (2), stuffing (2 cups chopped), gravy (¾ cup)
- [ ] Shallots · **3 large**
  Green beans (6 Tbsp chopped)
- [ ] Garlic · **2 heads**
  Turkey (12 cloves)
- [ ] Scallions · **1 large bunch**
  Stuffing (1 cup chopped)
- [ ] Flat-leaf parsley · **2 bunches**
  Stuffing (1 cup), carrots (⅓ cup)
- [ ] Fresh sage · **2 bunches**
  Turkey (1 bunch), stuffing (2 Tbsp minced)
- [ ] Fresh thyme · **2 bunches**
  Turkey (1 bunch), carrots (1½ tsp leaves)

Dairy

- [ ] Unsalted butter · **3 lb (12 sticks)**
  Stuffing 4 sticks · potatoes ~2 · gravy 1½ · green beans ¾ · turkey skin. Leaves a little extra.
- [ ] Heavy cream · **1 pint**
  Mashed potatoes, plus a splash when reheating

Bakery & nuts

- [ ] Good crusty bread · **2 large loaves (~3 lb)**
  Stuffing (12–16 cups coarse crumbs). Buy it early so it can go stale.
- [ ] Pine nuts or walnuts · **1 cup**
  Stuffing
- [ ] Pecans · **1 cup**
  Relish
- [ ] Hazelnuts, skinned if possible · **1 cup**
  Sprouts

Pantry

- [ ] Coarse kosher salt · **1 box**
  Turkey (~2½ Tbsp), potato water, everything else
- [ ] Sea salt · **small**
  Sprouts (1½ tsp)
- [ ] Whole black peppercorns · **1 jar**
  Turkey (1 Tbsp) and most of the other dishes
- [ ] Extra-virgin olive oil · **~1 cup**
  Sprouts (½ cup), carrots (4½ Tbsp)
- [ ] All-purpose flour · **¾ cup**
  Gravy
- [ ] Mild honey (clover) · **⅔ cup**
  Relish
- [ ] Pure maple syrup · **¼ cup**
  Sprouts
- [ ] Bay leaves · **3**
  Turkey
- [ ] Dried oregano · **¾ tsp**
  Carrots
- [ ] Whole nutmeg · **optional**
  Mashed potatoes

For the roasting pan

- [ ] Hard apple cider · **one 12-oz bottle**
  Turkey pan
- [ ] Dry white wine · **1 bottle**
  Turkey pan (1–2 cups); drink the rest

Supplies

- [ ] 2-gallon zip bag or brining bag · **1–2**
  Turkey dry brine
- [ ] Heavy-duty foil · **1 roll**
  Turkey breast, reheating, lining the sprout pans
- [ ] Paper towels · **plenty**
  Patting the turkey dry, storing the beans
- [ ] Instant-read thermometer · **if you don't have one**
  Turkey. You need one.

Scaled recipes

Ingredient amounts for 12, so nobody has to do the math at the stove. Click a recipe name to open the original PDF with the full method.

Simple Roast Turkey ↗

Melissa Clark

14–16 lb bird

- 1 turkey, 14–16 lb
- ~7½ tsp kosher salt (½ tsp per lb)
- 1 Tbsp black pepper
- 1 lemon, zested and quartered
- 1 bunch thyme, 1 bunch sage
- 12 garlic cloves, smashed
- 12 oz hard cider + white wine to ¼ inch
- 2 onions, quartered · 3 bay leaves
- Melted butter or olive oil for brushing

Time: 30 min at 450°F, then ~2–2½ hrs at 350°F until the thigh reads 165°F. Rest 30+ min.

Make-Ahead Gravy ↗

Mark Bittman

1½× · ~8 cups

- 12 Tbsp (1½ sticks) butter
- ¾ cup chopped onion
- ¾ cup flour
- 6–7½ cups rich stock, warmed
- Salt, pepper, turkey drippings

When: Tuesday night. Reheat over low heat Thursday and whisk in the drippings.

Bread Stuffing ↗

Mark Bittman

2× · two 9×13 dishes

- 1 lb (4 sticks) butter
- 2 cups chopped onion
- 1 cup pine nuts or chopped walnuts
- 12–16 cups coarse fresh bread crumbs
- 2 Tbsp minced fresh sage
- 1 cup chopped scallions
- 1 cup chopped parsley · salt, pepper

When: Wednesday, cooked and baked (~45 min at 375°F). Reheat Thursday at 400°F, covered.

Mashed Potatoes ↗

Melissa Clark

3× · ~12–15 servings

- 6 lb russet potatoes, peeled
- 9–18 Tbsp butter (about 1½–2 sticks)
- 1½ cups heavy cream, plus more
- Salt, pepper, nutmeg

When: Wednesday. Use your biggest pot, or split it between two. A ricer gives the fluffiest result.

Cranberry-Orange Relish ↗

Martha Rose Shulman

2× · 16 servings

- 2 bags fresh cranberries
- 2 navel oranges, skin on, in chunks
- 1 cup pecans
- ⅔ cup mild honey

When: Tuesday night. Process in two batches; it must be a food processor, not a blender.

Maple-Roasted Brussels Sprouts ↗

Tara Parker-Pope

2× · 12 servings

- 3 lb brussels sprouts, halved
- ½ cup olive oil
- 1½ tsp sea salt · ½ tsp pepper
- ¼ cup maple syrup
- 1 cup toasted hazelnuts, chopped

When: Wednesday, Steps 1–4 on two foil-lined pans. Thursday, roast about 15 min more and toss with the nuts.

Roasted Carrots ↗

Martha Rose Shulman

1½× · 9 servings

- 3 lb carrots
- 1½ tsp fresh thyme leaves
- 4½ Tbsp olive oil
- ¾ tsp dried oregano · salt, pepper
- ⅓ cup chopped parsley

When: Wednesday. Serve warm or at room temperature.

French Green Beans & Shallots ↗

Jacques Pépin

2× · 8 servings

- 2 lb thin green beans
- 6 Tbsp butter
- 6 Tbsp chopped shallots
- ½ tsp salt · ½ tsp pepper
- 2 tsp lemon juice

When: Blanch Wednesday. Sauté Thursday right before serving, in your widest pan (or in two batches).

About the portions: there are three vegetable sides plus potatoes and stuffing, so each side doesn't need to feed all 12 on its own. The potatoes, stuffing, and relish are scaled up the most because those are what people take seconds of and want as leftovers.

Equipment check

Find these before Tuesday.

- Large roasting pan with a rack
- Rimmed sheet pan that fits in the fridge (for the turkey)
- 2–3 more sheet pans (sprouts, carrots)
- Two 9×13 baking dishes (stuffing)
- A baking dish or pot for the potatoes
- Large stockpot, 8 qt or bigger
- Medium saucepan (gravy)

- Large deep skillet or Dutch oven (stuffing, beans)
- Food processor (relish, bread crumbs)
- Potato ricer or masher
- Colander, whisk, big mixing bowls
- Instant-read thermometer
- Carving board and knife
- Serving dishes and spoons for 8 dishes, plus a gravy boat

Recipes from NYT Cooking: Melissa Clark, Mark Bittman, Martha Rose Shulman, Jacques Pépin, Tara Parker-Pope. This page is a planning companion; the original recipes have the full methods.